

Verdict

When we think Gold, we think *outstanding product*. Going by this principle, it'd be easy to see why ASUS' P5B Premium Vista Edition gets top honours. At Rs 14,750, it's not for everyone, though. That's where our Silver winner comes in. At Rs 7400—the MSI P965 Platinum offers good features and build quality, and enough over-clocking features to justify the price tag.

We don't really recommend spending on a P965 board unless you *must* have the show-off features that the P5B Premium Vista Edition sports. Although this is an excellent chipset, it has been replaced in Intel's product line-up by the P35—a product that, while not markedly better, is definitely more future-proof.

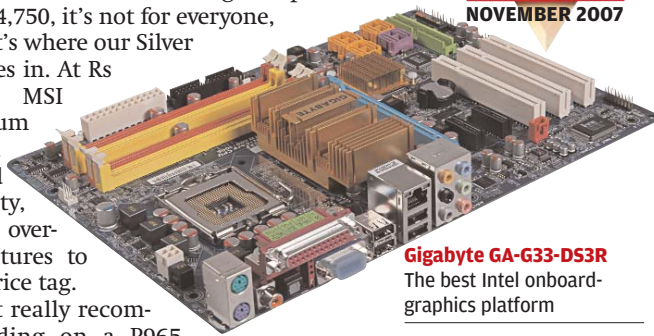
INTEGRATED GRAPHICS PLATFORMS

This category will be important for most—who needs a graphics card when you don't intend on gaming or doing a lot of HD movie-watching, right? We see boards for both Intel and AMD processors here. The players in this arena are more interested in the volume game, and such boards tend to be focused towards value for money rather than features, performance and overclocking—with a few exceptions, of course.

We've got boards based on Intel's latest G33 and G31 platforms, the older G965 platform and ATI's proven 690G. Newcomers were NVIDIA's GeForce 7050 and 7025—two very interesting platforms—and, of course, the older GeForce 6100 platform.

INTEL-BASED Features

Gigabyte's GA-G33-DS3R is a very well-built and attractive looking board. Even better, we liked the compact (Micro ATX) design on the GA-G33M-S2H. This board also has an HDMI port. Gigabyte has also included Realtek's latest ALC889A codec-based sound solution—the successor the de facto ALC888 codec. It's easy to see the former being pitched as a high-end product with integrated graphics, while the latter—with its reduced BIOS options—gives lesser expandability and smaller size being a home-entertainment product (hence the HDMI).



Gigabyte GA-G33-DS3R
The best Intel on-board-graphics platform

ECS' P33T-A board was an anomaly. While all the G33 and G31 boards are mated to the ICH9 Southbridge, this motherboard had an older ICH7 Southbridge—the same one on the much older 975X platform—a very negative move.

Abit's Fatal1ty F-190HD is another HDMI port-sporting board based around (surprise, surprise) ATI's 690G platform—which is basically a combination of Radeon x1250 graphics and an SB600 Southbridge. We figure this board is part of an endangered species—what with ATI having been taken over by AMD—which is a pity, simply because choice breeds competition, and Intel and NVIDIA have run out of the latter as far as platforms for Intel processors go. This board, despite bearing the "Fatal1ty" moniker, fails to impress as a hardcore enthusiast product.

Performance

To be honest, there's very little variety in the performance of the Intel-based motherboards—with the exception of the ECS P33T-A, though to be honest, with a Southbridge that is two generations old we expected this board to lag behind—particularly in the storage based tests. Surprisingly, it lagged in the graphics and gaming tests!

Both the Gigabyte boards do prove their mettle here, and both the MSI boards keep them close company.

Verdict

If you want an Intel-based solution, consider the duo from Gigabyte—the GA-G33-DS3R, (Rs 9,500) if you want something fast and feature rich and the GA-G33M-S2H, (Rs 5,950) if you're looking for unbeatable value and HDMI thrown into the kitty. Both these boards are very different beasts despite being from the same stable—the former is an enthusiast solution with greater overclockability, solid state capacitors and an ATX form factor and the latter is more for the cinema buff. These two steal our Gold and Silver awards—the GA-G33-DS3R placing first and its cheaper sibling placing second.

AMD-BASED Features

ASUS had two offerings—M2A-VM and M2A-VM HDMI. These are basically the same board with one difference—the presence of an HDMI port. Abit's AN-M2HD was a nice offering—micro ATX, a full 4 memory banks, HDMI, and a display solution that supports NVIDIA PureVideo.

Zebronics' ZEB-N61M2 was the old timer in this category—the GeForce 6100 is an older Northbridge, and the nForce 410 Southbridge has been around for some time as well.

Performance

The MSI K9AGM2 (690G) performs quite superbly, taking our X2 6400+ within striking distance of the newer X6800 (although a slight clock advantage is retained by the AMD part). In fact, one look at our CPU scores—especially under PC Mark 2005—will testify to the Gigabyte and MSI boards simply blowing away the other 690G based boards.

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